Standing Orders

A short story by Ben Coppage

Buffalo Soldiers Workshop

Reggie and Jahanara (Nara), the two main characters, each carry a small troop of soldiers, modeled on the Buffalo Soldiers of the 9th and 10th Cavalry. Each soldier stands for one strength. The soldiers are not real. Only their owner sees and hears them, and they never touch anything outside that person's head.

Part One

The restroom mirror at Tanner Way had not moved since Friday, and neither had Reggie's nose. Still bent left. Still a betrayal. The brown eyes were still two sizes. The bottom lip still curved wrong, a small thing nobody else would ever see.

Private Pell stood at his elbow. Pell was Accuracy. Small, quick hands, a blue wool coat with yellow cavalry piping, brass buttons he polished in his sleep. He counted things.

"Sixty," Pell said, as Reggie scrubbed. "Now thirty." Reggie rinsed for thirty.

Pell checked the collar of the beige oxford. The drop of the gray and white striped trousers. The cognac chukkas against the cognac belt. Sharp, never flashy. A man in Reggie's seat could be called a lot of things on that floor. Pell made sure flashy was never one of them. Pell made sure there was nothing to call him at all.

"Clean," Pell said. Then he leaned toward the glass and frowned at the curve of Reggie's bottom lip, and Reggie frowned too.

"That's enough, Private."

First Sergeant Mabry filled the doorway. Mabry was Composure. Tall, gray at the temples, his uniform pressed so hard it looked carved. He never raised his voice. He did not have to.

“Forty-five minutes,” Mabry said. “Get into character.”

Reggie dried his hands and walked into the dark.

#

The floor was a cavern at 05:15. White pillars, black tile, network cables hanging in their cage overhead. Rows of identical stations, each one marked with a nameplate, like graves. By the elevators hung a framed photo of a dialysis bloodline, coiled clean on a white background and lit like jewelry. On the break room board, a recall notice from August had curled at one corner. Lot numbers in bold. Nobody had taken it down.

The lights would come on at 06:00. Until then the floor belonged to him.

Corporal Lyle was already at Reggie’s station. Lyle was the Clerk. He was Relationships. Wire spectacles, a pencil behind one ear, a leather ledger thick with names. He opened it before Reggie sat down.

“Gloria Hampton, Southshore Family Health. Twenty-second anniversary Thursday. Husband is Carl. Her son starts at Northwestern in the fall. Call her before ten, never after three.” Lyle turned a page. “Dr. Vance at Lakeview Dialysis. Back surgery last month. Ask about the knee, not the back. He’s sensitive about the back.”

Reggie typed notes. Pell went through the weekend’s orders line by line, his lips moving. IV extension sets on backorder until the twentieth. A Lakeview line with a lot that expired in March, which was fine. A Southshore order in Sharon’s queue, entered Friday afternoon, status shipped. Pell’s eyes passed over it. Shipped was shipped.

At the edge of the station, where the monitor's light gave out, Scout Kane leaned on a pillar. Kane was Independence. He wore buckskin over his blues and carried his rifle like a walking stick. He rode alone. He always had.

"Look at them," Kane said, nodding at the empty chairs. "Every one of them thinks they're special. They read the company newsletter. They believe the part about family." He spat on the black tile, which Reggie would never have done. "You don't believe it. You hunt. You find your own meat. That's the difference."

Reggie did not answer. He did not need to. Kane spoke for him.

#

An email from Sharon sat at the top of his inbox. Sent Sunday at 23:48. *Won't be in tomorrow. Sorry for the short notice.*

No reason. Sharon always gave a reason. The dentist. Her mother. The furnace. Pell read the email twice and found nothing wrong with the grammar.

Reggie sent a request to Pat Delgado in Operations: *Need coverage for Sharon today. Must know the business. No time to train.*

Under Sharon's email sat a routine PO confirmation from Southshore purchasing. Someone in Contracts had added a name to the cc line: Dana Kessler, Regional Sales Director. Reggie's manager. Pell scrolled back through the folder. Four of the last ten confirmations had Kessler on them. Pell had never seen her name on a thread of Todd's, and Pell had looked.

Pell filed it. Pell filed everything.

#

"Sup, homie!"

Todd arrived with the lights. The fluorescents stuttered on overhead, and there he was. Skin almost luminescent, reddish at the edges, veins mapped under the skin of his neck. A sheen of sweat, though it was nine degrees outside. Bluish-gray eyes. That smirk. Todd always looked like he had just heard a joke about Reggie in the elevator.

Kane's hand went to his rifle.

Reggie would have preferred to smash his fucking face in and watch his blood stain the black tile, but that wouldn't go over too well with management and would severely impact team cohesion and morale. Mabry put a hand on Kane's shoulder, and the Scout stood down. At the desk, nothing moved but Reggie's smile.

"Morning, Todd," Reggie said. His voice was warm. Mabry had built that voice from parts.

"Where's Sharon?" Todd's bag was still on his shoulder.

"Out."

"Damn." Todd dropped the bag, then dropped himself after it. "Snow's crazy, bro. Trucks are already backed up on the Ryan. Southshore's gonna be screaming by lunch."

"Southshore's mine," Reggie said, pleasantly.

"I know, I know. Just saying. Rough day to be short-handed." Todd spun once in his chair. "Who's babysitting you?"

"We'll see."

Mabry nodded once. Well done. Reggie held the smile until Todd turned to his screen, then let it fall.

"He asked about Sharon before he sat down," Kane said.

"He's nosy," Mabry said.

Kane kept watching Todd's back.

The others filed in. The show began.

#

Jahanara took the company shuttle because the CTA buses were dingy and the people on them were worse. It meant arriving at 07:30 for an 08:00 shift. It also meant Kyle.

She called him Red Man, though never out loud. His skin was flushed like he was drunk or embarrassed. He was a lot older than her, and his eyes went up and down her every morning like he was checking a delivery.

"Mornin', Nara." It came out like a secret.

"Kyle," she said, as if she shared it, and took her seat behind the stairs.

Private Cathay was already in it. Cathay was Adaptability. She was hard to look at directly, because her face never settled. With Kyle it went easy and soft. She asked about the Bears. She asked about the quarterback's ankle twice, because twice was the right number. Once looked rude. Three times looked interested. Cathay had once worn a man's name to get into the army. She could wear anything.

Snow fell past the windows on Michigan Avenue, slow at first, then not. Jahanara caught her reflection in the side mirror. Puffy lids. Brown eyes. The scar that traced the curve of her left chin and ran up to her lip.

Trooper Moss had the same scar. Moss was Resilience. He stood in the aisle holding the rail, old, a bad knee locked straight, a worse back, snow on his campaign hat. He had earned the scar sliding into home plate a long time ago. He had scored. He did not talk about it much anymore.

"Tired," Moss said.

"I'm fine."

"I know. That's what I'm here for."

Corporal Odessa Greene carried the haversack. Odessa was Loyalty. Broad back, broad laugh, a canvas sack on her shoulder that she never set down. None of what was in it was hers. A pink hair tie for Jada. Her father's birthday in Miami, the second week of March, a list of flights. Jahiza's number, starred, because Jahiza's girl Kiara was in trouble again and Saturday lunch was the only chance to talk. Michael, who would need to be told to shovel the walk.

Jahanara reread the text she had sent Michaella from the platform. *Yes I'll keep Jada Friday. Pick up NO LATER than Saturday morning.*

Sergeant Ruth Albright had written that. Albright was the Interpreter. She was Negotiation. Lean and precise, her stripes sewn on crooked as if she had done it in a hurry. She stood at the gate of every fort and spoke terms.

"Saturday morning," Albright said. "It's in writing. And at noon, call Michael about the walk."

"He'll say later."

"Then you'll tell him when later is."

The shuttle reached its last stop. The sky had gone gray and white, and the snow was sticking. Jahanara exhaled. Cathay straightened and went smooth, a different woman in the same coat. Jahanara stepped into the Tanner Way lobby like a woman taking a stage.

#

The fourth floor was Order Management. No framed photos. A quality training reminder taped to every monitor: *Lot traceability is patient safety. Module 4 due Friday.* A sample case of sterile procedure kits sat on the corner of Pat's desk, wrap still sealed, holding his door open.

Jahanara had worked on four for eleven years. She knew the warehouse leads by voice. She knew which carriers lied about cutoffs.

She had her coat half off when Pat Delgado leaned out of his office.

“Nara. Need a favor. Sharon’s out upstairs. Reggie’s desk.”

Odessa’s sack shifted on her shoulder. Cathay was already smiling.

“Reggie,” Jahanara said.

She knew the name. Everybody on four knew it. One of the few Black reps upstairs. She had heard him described in the break room by people who had never sat with him. Intense. A lot. Particular. She had heard the same words about herself, years ago, on a different floor.

“He asked for somebody who knows the business,” Pat said. “That’s you.” He handed her a sticky note with a station number. “He’s particular.”

“I heard.”

“Just keep him from killing anyone.”

She put her coat back on. She did not need it to go upstairs. But it felt better, walking in, to be covered.

Part Two

She did not carry herself like a fill-in. That was the first thing Pell noted. She carried herself like someone who had run a desk longer than Reggie had run his. The second thing was the scar, chin to lip. The third was the coat, still on.

Pell reached up and straightened Reggie's collar. He had already straightened it at 05:15. Mabry looked at him. Pell lowered his hands.

"Jahanara," she said. "Order Management. Pat sent me."

"Reggie." He stood, shook her hand, sat. Her grip was dry and brief. "Sharon's queue is on her screen. Calls go to her line. Orders come in through the portal. You know the portal."

"I know the portal."

"Great." He turned back to his monitor.

That was the training.

Kane grinned from his pillar. "Told them no hand-holding. She swims or she doesn't."

Lyle glanced up from his ledger and opened his mouth, then closed it. There was no page for her. She was not a client.

#

Cathay took the chair first. She hung the coat on its back, smoothed it, and made herself small. Nothing on the desk was moved. Sharon's stapler stayed where Sharon kept it. Sharon's sticky notes stayed stuck to the edge of the monitor. One of them said *T: Thurs?* in Sharon's round hand. Cathay did not touch it.

"He's rude," Odessa said.

"He's busy," Cathay said. "Don't take up room."

But Cathay looked at him once, the way she looked at everyone, to read what he needed. She saw the gray in his beard, early, peppered through the black. The belt that matched the shoes. The fade so fresh it was a statement. Somebody had planned every inch of this man. Cathay knew what that took. For one second she forgot to be small. She sat up in the chair like it was hers.

Then she remembered, and folded back down.

Moss, leaning on Sharon's filing cabinet, straightened too. He did not know why.

#

Jahanara opened the queue. Forty-one open lines. She went through them the way she had for eleven years, fast and without noise. A dialysis center short two cases of bloodlines that Bedford Park could cover. A hospital purchasing office asking for GPO pricing on pump replacement parts. A backorder notice to send.

At 09:15 she stopped.

Southshore Family Health. Order 88214. Infusion sets, SKU IS-2240. Entered Friday at 16:52. Quantity: 40. Unit: EA.

Southshore never ordered eaches. Their history was all cases. Forty cases, every month, like a heartbeat. Forty eaches was one case. A shoebox.

She opened the audit trail out of habit. Entered by SWALSH. Sharon. Friday, eight minutes before the end of the day. It looked like what it looked like. Somebody tired, rushing, hitting the wrong field. Jahanara had seen it a thousand times.

Albright was already at the gate. "Tell him. Plain. 'This order is wrong.'"

Cathay leaned in. "He doesn't know you. Make it a question."

"Reggie," Jahanara said. "Quick question. Southshore. Did they want eaches this time?"

He didn't look up. "Whatever's in the system is what they want."

"It's usually cases."

"Then they changed it." He was typing. "I've had that account three years."

Cathay nodded. Fine. Let it go. Moss sighed and kept walking, the way he did when a road went nowhere he hadn't seen before. Albright wrote nothing down. A term not spoken is not a term.

Jahanara flagged the line yellow and moved on.

#

At 10:05 Dana Kessler came down the row with a coffee and a tablet. Silver bob, fleece vest with the Tanner Way logo, the walk of someone who owned the carpet.

Mabry stood up straight before Reggie did. He put a flat hand on Reggie's back, the way he always did when Kessler came by. Pell noted the time. He always did that too.

"Reggie. I heard the Lakeview call Friday. You're so articulate with the clinical people. Really."

"Thank you, Dana."

"Southshore review is next Tuesday, right? Todd's got some bandwidth. Want him to sit in? Fresh eyes."

Kane's rifle came off the pillar.

"I've got it covered," Reggie said. Warm voice. Easy smile.

"Just offering." Kessler turned to the desk beside him. "And you are?"

"Jahanara. Order Management. Covering for Sharon."

"Great. Keep him honest." Kessler laughed and moved on down the row. She stopped at Todd's station and stayed longer.

Jahanara watched Reggie's face. It did not move. That was what gave it away. A face that did not move after a thing like that was a face doing work.

Cathay knew that face. She had worn it in a hundred offices. On a different floor, years ago, a manager had told Jahanara she was very well spoken. She had said thank you. She had said it in the same voice Reggie had just used.

Odessa looked at Reggie for a long time. She did not reach for the sack. Not yet.

#

At 10:40 Gloria Hampton called.

Lyle leapt to his feet, ledger open. *Anniversary Thursday. Carl. Northwestern.*

"Gloria! How are you holding up in this snow? Carl still shoveling for you?"

"Reggie." Her voice was flat. "The truck came. It was one box."

Pell went white under his brass.

"I have patients in chairs from seven tomorrow morning," Gloria said. "I have sets for maybe six of them. My receiving guy opened that box twice because he thought he was missing something. Tell me what happened."

Lyle was still reading from the ledger. "Ask about her son. She likes to talk about her son."

"I'm on it," Reggie said. "And hey. Congratulations on Thursday. Twenty-two years."

A pause long enough to fall into.

"I don't need you to remember my anniversary," Gloria said. "I need forty cases."

She hung up.

Lyle closed the ledger slowly. He looked at the cover like it had lied to him.

#

The line Jahanara had flagged sat on her screen in yellow. Reggie saw it when he leaned over to read Sharon's queue.

He saw the time stamp on the flag. 09:16.

Kane spoke first. He always did. "She knew, and she let you walk into it. Asked a question like a schoolgirl. You wanted people who don't need direction? That's what you get. People who won't take a position."

Pell was building the email to Gloria. Subject line, version one. Version two. *Regarding your recent order.* No. *Correction to Order 88214.* No. He moved a comma. He moved it back. He decided "regret" was weak and "apologize" was weaker. Six drafts. Eleven minutes. The clock in the corner of the screen did not care.

"Find the stock," Mabry said quietly.

"The email has to be right," Pell said. "Kessler will read it."

"Find the stock."

Todd rolled his chair over. He had heard. Todd always heard. He had the look of a man walking up on a car wreck with his phone out.

"One box, huh?" Todd shook his head. "That's rough, homie."

Reggie had not said one box out loud. Kane noticed. Nobody else had time to.

"He give you any training, sweetheart?" Todd winked at Jahanara. "He's like that with everybody. Don't take it personal." Then, to Reggie: "Want me to call Gloria? I know her guy in receiving."

Kane's rifle came up. In Reggie's mind it fired, and Todd's veins finally opened onto the black tile, and that was fine. That was beautiful. None of it happened. Todd kept smiling. The tile stayed clean.

Mabry stepped between them and closed his hand around the barrel.

"I've got it, Todd," Reggie said. Warm voice. Warm smile. "Appreciate you."

Todd rolled away, humming.

An email landed. Kessler to Reggie, cc Todd. *Saw Southshore had a delivery issue. Looping in Todd for support, he knows their team. Let's make sure we're covered. D.*

Pell checked the times. Gloria had hung up at 10:43. Kessler's email came at 10:55. Reggie had told no one.

Reggie turned to Jahanara. His voice was very calm. It was the calmest thing on the floor.

"I asked Operations for someone who didn't need training," he said. "You saw a bad order at nine-fifteen and you flagged it yellow. Yellow. For a clinic."

She looked at him for one second. Albright stood at the gate with her mouth open, and nothing came out.

"OK," Jahanara said.

He went to the restroom. Mabry walked beside him. Mabry had kept Reggie's voice even the whole time. He had done nothing about what Reggie said with it.

#

Odessa watched him go. "He's hurting," she said.

"He's wrong," Albright said.

"Both," said Moss.

Jahanara looked at the yellow line. Her flag. Her time stamp. Her name in the order history now, next to Sharon's. If anyone pulled this order later, the first thing they would see was someone on loan from four who saw it and did nothing.

She did not dig for him. She dug because her name was on it.

She pulled stock first, because that was what you did. Bedford Park showed twenty-two cases of IS-2240. Milwaukee showed thirty, all on hold. The hold was for Ridgeway Clinic. Account manager: TBRANDT. Todd. Ridgeway had not ordered in sixty-two days. The hold was placed Thursday at 14:10.

She opened the Southshore order template, because Sharon would have used one. Every assistant did. The template's change log had one entry in the last year. Thursday, 14:32. Default unit changed from CS to EA. User: SWALSH.

Twenty-two minutes after Todd parked the stock.

She sat back. Sharon's sticky note was still on the monitor. *T: Thurs?*

She opened the shared Southshore order inbox. It kept a copy of everything sent from it. Last Tuesday, 11:20. Sharon had forwarded Southshore's GPO contract pricing sheet. Not to Reggie. To Todd. No message. Just the attachment.

Albright was at the gate, and this time her voice was hard. "Tell him. Tell Pat. Tell somebody."

"Tell them what?" Cathay said. "You're on loan from four. Eleven years down there doesn't count up here. You've been up here three hours. You're going to walk into that director's office and say the white rep and the assistant set up the Black rep?"

Albright had nothing for that. Neither did Moss.

"It's not ours," Cathay said.

Odessa took it. All of it. The hold, the template, the forwarded sheet, the sticky note. She put it in the sack with the rest. It was not Jahanara's to carry, so of course Odessa carried it.

Her phone buzzed. Michaella.

Hey ma change of plans. Can I bring Jada TONIGHT? Concert got moved. We'll get her Sunday promise.

Odessa was reaching before Jahanara finished reading. There was always room in the sack. "Say yes. She's your baby's baby."

Albright: "You said Saturday morning. In writing."

Cathay: "Don't make a fight out of it. You're at work."

OK, Jahanara typed.

She called Michael. It rang five times.

"Yeah."

"Can you do the walk before I get home? It's coming down hard."

"Later."

"When is later?"

"Later, Nara. Damn."

He hung up. Albright looked at her own hands.

Then Jahiza texted. *Call me when you can. It's bad with Kiara again.* Odessa took that too. The sack was so full now it dragged on the tile. It made no sound. Nothing the soldiers did made sound. It was only weight in Jahanara's shoulders.

Moss sat down next to her. He had never sat down before. His bad knee stuck straight out in front of him like a fence post.

"We'll get through it," Moss said.

"And then what?"

He didn't have an answer. He used to. He used to say *and then it gets better.* Now he just said *we'll get through it*, the way you say grace over food you didn't pick.

She went back to the queue. She did the other forty lines. She did them right. She did not touch Southshore.

#

In the mirror, the nose was still bent. The lip still curved wrong. Pell was counting the chicken pox scars on Reggie's right cheek. Seven. There had always been seven.

Kane paced. "Send her back to four. Call Pat. You don't need her. You don't need any of them."

Lyle sat on the sink with his ledger shut in his lap. "Gloria heard it," he said. "The way I talk. She heard it."

"Kessler cc'd Todd," Pell said. "Twelve minutes. Who told her?"

Nobody answered.

Mabry stood at the door, as he always did. Composed. Pressed. He had kept Reggie's hands still for three years. He had kept them still for a lot longer than that. Since a summer by the lake, and a girl who played piano.

"You can't go back out there like this," Mabry said.

"Like what?" Reggie said. "I'm calm."

"Yes," said Mabry. "That's the problem."

Outside the window at the end of the hall, the snow came down sideways and stuck to everything.

Part Three

Mabry did not raise his voice in the restroom either.

“They gave the Tenth the worst horses in the army,” he said. “The worst posts. Officers who wouldn’t eat with them. Every mistake a trooper made got written up twice. The Tenth still rode, and rode well. You know why?”

Reggie looked at him in the mirror.

“Discipline,” Mabry said. “Not silence. I was never supposed to be the thing that keeps your mouth shut. I’m the thing that keeps your hands steady while you say it.”

Kane laughed. “Say what?”

“That he was wrong. To her. Now.”

“And Todd?”

“Todd comes after the stock.”

Pell stopped counting scars. Seven. It would always be seven. He turned away from the glass.

“Forget the email,” Mabry said. “Pell. What do we need?”

Pell’s hands came alive. “Thirty-nine cases. Southshore’s first patient is at seven. Bedford Park cutoff for same-day courier is 13:00. It’s 12:10.”

“Kane.”

The Scout uncrossed his arms. “I don’t work with people.”

“You find things nobody else finds. Find stock.”

“And Lyle,” Mabry said. “Close the book. You’re about to talk to someone you don’t have notes on.”

#

Reggie came back and did not sit down. He stood at the side of her desk so she would not have to look up at him.

“I was out of line,” he said. “You saw it at nine-fifteen. You told me, and I told you I’d had the account three years. That’s on me. Not you.”

Cathay started to smile. *It’s fine. Don’t worry about it.* The words were already in Jahanara’s mouth.

Albright stepped in front of them.

“I’ll help you fix it,” Jahanara said. “Two things. You talk to me straight, the way you just did. And you don’t talk over me in front of him.” She did not look toward Todd. She did not have to. “If either one happens again, I go back to four, and Pat finds you somebody else.”

Kane bristled. Mabry let him.

“Deal,” Reggie said.

Albright wrote it down. Then she did something new. She stood behind the term instead of in front of it.

Jahanara looked at the yellow line, then at him. Odessa shifted the sack. It was heavy with things that were not Jahanara’s, and for the first time Odessa wanted to set some of it down.

“Pull your chair over,” Jahanara said. “Don’t make a face.”

He pulled his chair over. She turned her monitor a few degrees toward him. Her voice was low and even, the voice you use to read lot numbers.

“Milwaukee has thirty cases of IS-2240. All held for Ridgeway. Owner TBRANDT. Ridgeway hasn’t ordered in sixty-two days. Hold placed Thursday, 14:10.” She clicked. “Southshore’s order template. Default unit changed from CS to EA. Thursday, 14:32.

SWALSH.” She clicked again. “Shared inbox. Last Tuesday. Sharon sent Southshore’s GPO pricing to Todd. No message.”

She touched the sticky note on the monitor with one finger. *T: Thurs?*

Reggie read it all once. Pell read it three times. Kane’s eyes went bright. He knew a trail when he saw one.

“Walk it to Kessler,” Kane said. “Put it on her desk. Now.”

Lyle shook his head. “A rep blaming his own assistant and the guy at the next desk. For his own bad order. You know how that sounds.”

“It sat in our queue all weekend,” Pell said. “Ours. I passed it this morning. Shipped was shipped.” He looked sick saying it.

Mabry spoke last. “And you know what Kessler hears before she reads a single login. She hears the tone. She already used the word articulate today.”

Reggie could not see Jahanara’s soldiers. He could see what they did to her face. Something in there had already done this math.

“I’m not saying it out loud,” she said. “I’m on loan from four. I’ve been up here four hours.”

“No,” Reggie said. “Neither am I.”

She nodded once. He had not had to explain it. That was the strange part. He had never explained it to anyone in three years, because he had never tried. She had sat down at Sharon’s desk and known.

Kane watched her the way he watched Todd. “Careful,” he said. “You don’t know her.”

Across the desk, where Reggie could not see, Odessa opened the sack and moved things around. Not to put something in. To make room.

“So we fix it,” Jahanara said.

“We fix it. And we write down every time stamp.”

“Already did.” She opened a text file. Times, logins, actions. Nothing else.

Pell almost smiled.

#

“Bedford Park has twenty-two,” she said. “The lead is Luis. If you call him, he’ll tell you the cutoff is one. If I call him, he’ll hold the courier until one-thirty. He owes me from the Christmas recall.”

That was Cathay. Eleven years of reading people, of matching her voice to theirs. It was the same skill she had used on Red Man that morning. The difference was where it pointed. This time she was the one who got something.

“Call Luis,” Reggie said. “I’ll get Milwaukee. Not from Todd. From allocation.”

Kane frowned. “Allocation takes a ticket.”

“Then it takes a ticket.”

She called Luis. Her voice changed on the second word. Lower, with some Southwest Side in it that Reggie had not heard all morning. She laughed once at something Luis said. It was a real laugh. Reggie’s attention went to her mouth, to the scar where it met her lip, and stayed there a beat too long. Pell straightened Reggie’s collar a third time. Mabry let him.

“Thirteen-thirty,” she said, covering the phone. “He wants it in writing.”

“Send it.”

She typed it while Luis was still talking. SKU, case count, lot numbers, expiration dates, ship-to, receiving hours, a contact at the Southshore dock. No adjectives. She sent it before the call ended. Luis said something. She said, “I know you will.”

Reggie wrote the allocation ticket. Pell checked every field. Kane found the policy in four minutes: a hold on sterile stock for an account with no open order could be released for documented patient need. Ridgeway had no open order. Southshore had patients at seven. Reggie attached the order number and Gloria's call time, routed the ticket to the allocation desk, and copied Pat. He did not copy Kessler. Not yet.

They did not talk much for forty minutes. They did not need to. She called out a lot number, and he had it typed before she finished. He asked for the dock hours, and she had already pulled them. Once they both reached for the same sticky pad and both stopped. She took it. He let her.

Cathay did not change her face once the whole time. There was nobody at the desk she needed to be for.

Moss, still in his chair, sat up straight.

At 12:58 Luis confirmed the truck.

#

At 13:05 the allocation desk released eighteen cases. The system sent a notice to the hold owner. Reggie watched Todd read it.

Todd rolled over. No phone out this time.

"Damn, homie. You went to allocation on me? You could've just asked."

"I followed the process."

"Ridgeway's gonna need those."

"Ridgeway hasn't ordered in sixty-two days," Reggie said. He kept his voice even. That part had not changed. What changed was what came next. "And don't call me homie. Don't call her sweetheart."

The smirk held for a second. Then it slipped, like Todd had heard the joke for the first time and found out who it was on. His eyes went to Jahanara, then to Sharon's monitor. To the sticky note. Then away.

"Touchy," Todd said. He rolled back to his station. He did not hum.

Kane wanted more. Kane wanted blood on the tile. Mabry kept his hand on the barrel, and this time Reggie did not resent it. The rage was still there. He had just said it out loud, in a shorter version, to the person who earned it. It weighed less.

#

Twenty-two from Bedford Park. Eighteen from Milwaukee. Forty cases, one more than they needed, because Pell insisted. The courier would reach Southshore by 06:30 if the Dan Ryan stayed open.

Reggie called Gloria. Lyle sat beside him with the ledger shut.

"Gloria. It's Reggie. The order was entered wrong on Friday. Eaches instead of cases. I missed it. Someone on my team caught it this morning, and I didn't listen. Forty cases arrive by six-thirty tomorrow. We're crediting the freight. If the courier slips, I'll call you myself before six."

Silence. Not the bad kind this time.

"OK," Gloria said. "Thank you for telling me straight." A beat. "Funny thing. Somebody from your office called our purchasing Friday afternoon. Asked if we were happy with our coverage."

Kane went very still.

"Who?" Reggie said.

"Linda took it. I didn't ask." Another beat. "Are we covered, Reggie?"

“You’re covered. By me.”

“Don’t do it again.”

“I won’t.”

She hung up without mentioning Thursday. Lyle opened the ledger anyway and wrote something. Not her anniversary. *Wants it straight. Remember that first.* Under it, smaller: *Purchasing: Linda. Friday call. Ask nothing. Watch.*

#

Reggie wrote the recap at 13:40. Pell wanted to make it perfect. Mabry made him make it accurate instead.

Jahanara read the draft over his shoulder. Her coat sleeve was an inch from his arm. Neither of them moved it.

“Take out the Tuesday line,” she said. “The pricing. That one’s an accusation. The rest is a timeline.”

He took it out. “Anything else?”

“Put in my flag at 09:16. Don’t put in that you ignored it.”

“I told Gloria.”

“Gloria’s not your boss.”

Albright nodded. Odessa did too. Reggie could not see either of them. He saw Jahanara’s chin lift a quarter inch and understood he had been given something.

“And lock the template,” she said. “Then nobody has to ask why it changed.”

He added the line. Then, after a second, he added one more. She read it twice. She did not tell him to take it out.

To: Pat Delgado
Cc: Dana Kessler

Subject: Southshore Order 88214: timeline and correction

Thu 14:10. Milwaukee hold placed on 30 CS, IS-2240, for Ridgeway Clinic. Owner TBRANDT. Ridgeway last order: 62 days.

Thu 14:32. Southshore order template default unit changed from CS to EA. User SWALSH.

Fri 16:52. Order 88214 entered, 40 EA. User SWALSH. Account history: CS only.

Mon 09:16. Unit discrepancy flagged by Jahanara (Order Management, covering).

Mon 10:43. Customer reported short shipment. Patients scheduled Tuesday 07:00.

Mon 12:58. Bedford Park, 22 CS. Courier held to 13:30.

Mon 13:05. Milwaukee hold released through allocation desk for patient need. 18 CS.

Tue 06:30. ETA at Southshore. Freight credited.

Southshore order template reset to CS and locked to account owner.

Southshore contract pricing restricted to account owner.

Pell read it three times. Mabry kept Reggie's hand steady on the mouse. Reggie sent it.

Kessler answered in six minutes. *Thanks Reggie. Great hustle today. Let's chat Tuesday about support on this account.*

"Support," Kane said.

Pat answered in two. *Read it. Thanks.* Nothing else.

Pell looked at Pat's reply for a long time. "He read the logins," Pell said.

"Maybe," said Mabry.

#

At 15:10 Jahanara opened Michaella's thread.

Odessa held the sack out to her. It was still heavy. Jada was in it, and her father's March flights, and Jahiza's girl. The things from Sharon's queue were gone. Reggie was carrying those now. Odessa was not wrong to carry the rest. She had just never put Jahanara in.

You can bring her tonight, Jahanara typed. *Pickup Saturday, 10 a.m. If you're not here by 10, I'm bringing her to you.*

The dots came and went three times.

Wow ok

That was not agreement. It didn't need to be. Albright had not asked a question.

She texted Michael. *Walk done by 6 or I pay the Ramirez boy $40 and you pay me back.*

No answer. She would find out at six. Moss stood up off the chair, slowly, knee first. He didn't say *it gets better.* He said, "Let's see," and for the first time in a while it sounded like a plan and not a prayer.

She called Jahiza on her break. She told her sister she would be at Saturday lunch, alone, and she would stay the full two hours.

#

At 16:15 Pat emailed. *Sharon is out tomorrow too. No reason given. Can Nara stay up there?*

Reggie read *no reason given* twice. Kane looked at Todd's empty chair. Todd had left at four. Todd never left at four.

Reggie started to type *yes* to Pat. Then he stopped and turned his chair.

"Sharon's out tomorrow," he said. "Would you cover again?"

Jahanara considered him. Cathay offered a soft yes. Albright offered a better one.

"Eight to four-thirty," she said. "My shuttle leaves at four-forty. I don't miss it."

"Eight to four-thirty."

"And when I flag something yellow, you read it."

"I'll read it."

She put her coat on at 16:30 exactly and walked to the elevator. She did not look back to see if he was watching.

He was. Kane said, “Careful.” Reggie did not let Kane speak for him this time. He did not answer him at all.

#

Reggie went to wash his hands. Pell counted sixty out of habit, then thirty.

The nose was still bent left. The lip still curved. Pell looked, and Reggie looked, and after a while they both looked away.

None of it was fixed. Todd would be back tomorrow, a little more careful, which was worse. Kessler wanted to talk about support on Tuesday. Sharon was out with no reason given. Somebody had called Linda in purchasing, and nobody had said who. The new construction homes were still delusions. But he knew which soldier had been running things for three years, and he knew it was not the one who should.

He went back to his desk and wrote her an email.

Subject: Tomorrow
Yellow gets read. See you at 8.
R
Pell reached for it. Reggie sent it before he could.

#

Outside, the snow had stopped.

“Evenin’, Nara,” Kyle said, like a secret.

“I want to sit in the back today.”

“Sure, Nara.”

She let him keep his secret. She walked past the seat behind the stairs to the back, where the heater was weak and nobody would talk to her.

Her phone buzzed at 16:41. She read it once.

Cathay did not arrange her face. There was nobody on the shuttle to arrange it for. Moss sat up straight across the aisle, his bad leg out, and said nothing at all. Odessa reached for the sack, out of habit.

Jahanara shook her head. Not that one.

She put the phone in her coat pocket and kept her hand on it. She sat where she wanted.

Strategy

First, notice which soldier is in charge. When one strength runs the whole army, it causes harm. Composure can cover an insult. Loyalty can carry weight that belongs to someone else.

Second, name the conflict directly and early, to the person involved. Do not hide it behind a calm face or a soft question.

Third, when you cannot name a conflict openly, do not bury it and do not shout it. Fix the problem first. Write down times and actions with no adjectives. Close the openings that let it happen. Let the record speak to anyone who reads it carefully.

Fourth, set terms you will keep with the people you can reach. State them plainly, and act on them if they are broken. Put the right soldier forward for the moment: honesty for a mistake, skill for a problem, firmness for a boundary, the record for a fight you cannot name.

Army Roster

Soldier	Character	Type	Strength shown	Backfire shown	Scenes
First Sergeant Mabry (Composed)	Reggie	Personal	Holds back his rage at Todd. Runs the 45-minute routine. Keeps Reggie's face still when Kessler doubts him. Steadies his hand on the recap.	Keeps Reggie's voice calm while he blames Jahanara for the missed order. Buries his anger at Todd and Kessler behind a warm voice.	Part One: restroom, Todd's greeting. Part Two: Kessler's visit, "Yellow. For a clinic," the mirror. Part Three: Tenth Cavalry speech, the apology, confronts Todd, the recap.
Scout Kane (Independent)	Reggie	Personal	Rejects the company story. Notices Todd asked about Sharon first and knew it was "one box." Finds the allocation policy in four minutes.	Gives Jahanara no training and blames her for the missed order. Wants to accuse Todd openly. Distrusts Jahanara.	Part One: the empty floor, Todd's arrival. Part Two: "no hand-holding," blames the yellow flag, the mirror. Part Three: the evidence, the allocation ticket, "Careful."
Corporal Lyle, the Clerk (Relationship builder)	Reggie	Professional	Tracks Gloria's anniversary, her son, and her call times.	Reggie performs small talk during a crisis. Gloria hears the act and hangs up.	Part One: client review. Part Two: Gloria's call, the mirror. Part Three: how it sounds to accuse, the honest call to Gloria, new ledger entries.
Private Pell, the Armorer (Accurate)	Reggie	Professional	Counts the hand wash and checks every clothing item. Tracks who gets cc'd. Checks every ticket field, case count, and time stamp.	Passes the bad Southshore order because it says shipped. Rewrites one email six times while stock runs out. Counts the scars on Reggie's face.	Part One: mirror, order review, the Kessler cc pattern. Part Two: Kessler's visit, email drafts, the mirror. Part Three: cases and cutoffs, the collar, the recap.
Corporal Odessa Greene (Loyal / caring)	Jahanara	Personal	Carries Jada's hair tie, her father's birthday plans, and Jahiza's crisis. Makes room for Reggie.	Agrees to take Jada a night early and keep her until Sunday. Takes the evidence from Sharon's queue as weight that is not hers.	Part One: shuttle. Part Two: Kessler's visit, the evidence, Michaella's and Jahiza's texts. Part Three: makes room, hands the sack back, the shuttle.
Private Cathay (Adaptable)	Jahanara	Personal	Reads Red Man and walks into work like stepping onto a stage. Reads Reggie's act. Gets Luis to hold the courier.	Turns a clear warning into a soft question. Makes herself small at Sharon's desk. Talks Jahanara out of speaking up.	Part One: shuttle and lobby. Part Two: first meeting, the Southshore question, Kessler's visit, "It's not ours." Part Three: Luis, the fix, the shuttle.

Soldier	Character	Type	Strength shown	Backfire shown	Scenes
Sergeant Ruth Albright, the Interpreter (Negotiator)	Jahanara	Professional	Sets the Saturday-morning pickup. Sets terms with Reggie. Cuts the accusation from the recap and keeps the facts.	Terms collapse: Michaella moves the date, Michael says “later,” and she says only “OK” to Reggie.	Part One: the text to Michaella. Part Two: the Southshore question, “OK,” the call to Michael. Part Three: terms with Reggie, the recap, Michaella, Michael, the 4:30 hours.
Trooper Moss (Resilient)	Jahanara	Professional	Shows up tired and still performs. Carries the softball scar from the winning run. Sits up straight during the fix.	Sits down for the first time. Endures with no belief that things will get better.	Part One: shuttle. Part Two: first meeting, the Southshore question, “And then what?” Part Three: the fix, “Let’s see,” the shuttle.